national security. Snowden was optimistic things would change for the better. But by 2010, after two years in office, it seemed to Snowden that Obama had reversed course on surveillance and was no better than his predecessor, George W. Bush.

In 2010, Snowden was working as a technical expert in Japan for Dell, a company that did top-secret work for the NSA. It was an ideal job for Snowden, because he had always wanted to visit Japan. He worked near Tokyo in an NSA office at the Yokota Air Base, teaching military personnel how to defend their computers from hackers. The position gave him access to new information, such as mass surveillance programs, targeted killings, and CIA drone attacks. He also

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In 2008, during the Democratic primary for president, US Senator Barack Obama said he would end many Bush-era policies, such as illegal surveillance. In a January 2008 speech at Dartmouth College in New Hampshire, Obama said that under his presidency, the United States would leave behind "wiretaps without warrants."[5] He opposed amendments to the Foreign Intelligence Surveillance Act (FISA) that would allow telecommunication companies to avoid prosecution for participating in NSA wiretap programs. Then, four months later, Obama changed course, saying he would vote for a compromise bill in favor of the FISA amendments. Though the change disappointed many of his Democratic primary supporters, it made him appear strong on defense for the general election.

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